CAUSE-EFFECT PATTERN

The cause-and-effect pattern is commonly found in academic writing either as a type of essay on its own, or as part of a longer essay in which one or more paragraphs examine causes and effects. In this lesson, we will discuss what a cause-and-effect essay is, how to structure this type of essay, and how to use cause and effect structure words (transition signals) for this type of essay. There is also an example cause and effect essay on the topic of women at work, as well as some exercises to help you practice this pattern.

What are cause-and-effect essays?

A cause-and-effect essay looks at the reasons (or causes) for something and then discusses the results (or effects). This pattern is one of the most common ways of organizing ideas in academic writing. Sometimes the whole essay will be about causes and effects, though sometimes this pattern may be found in only part of the whole essay. It is also possible that only the causes or the effects, and not both, are discussed. See the examples below.

- Discuss the causes and effects of global warming [cause and effect essay]
- Explain the high death rate in Chernobyl [causes only essay]
- Discuss the WTO and its effects on the Chinese economy [effects only essay]

Structure

There are two main ways to structure a cause-and-effect essay, namely using a block or a chain structure. For the block structure, all of the causes are listed first, and all of the effects are listed afterwards. For the chain structure, each cause is followed immediately by an effect. Usually that effect will then be the cause of the next effect, which is why this structure is called "chain." Both types of structure have their merits. The former is generally clearer, especially for shorter essays, while the latter ensures that any effects presented relate directly to the causes given.

The two types of structure, block and chain, are shown in the diagram below:

Block	Chain
Introduction ▪ Cause 1 ▪ Cause 2 ▪ … Transition sentence/paragraph ▪ Effect 1 ▪ Effect 2 ▪ … Conclusion	Introduction ▪ Cause 1 & Effect of Cause 1 ▪ Cause 2 & Effect of Cause 2 ▪ Cause 3 & Effect of Cause 3 ▪ … Conclusion

Cause-and-Effect Structure Words

Cause-and-effect structure words are transition signals which show cause and effect relationships. It is important to be clear which is the cause (or reason) and which is the effect (or result), and to use the correct transition word or phrase. Remember that a cause happens first, and the effect happens later.

Below are some common cause-and-effect structure words. “X” is used to indicate a cause, while “Y” is used to indicate the effect.

Cause
- The first cause of (Y) is (X)
- The next reason is (X)
- Because of (X), (Y)
- As a result of (X), (Y)
- As a consequence of (X), (Y)
- because/since/as (X)
- (X) results in (Y)
- to be the result of (X)
- (Y) is due to (X)
- Owing to (X), (Y)
- (Y) is because of (X)
- (Y) is the effect of (X)
- (Y) is the consequence of (X)

Effect
- One effect of (X) is (Y)
- Another result of (X) is (Y)
- As a result, (Y)
- As a consequence, (Y)
- Consequently (Y)
- Therefore, (Y)
- Thus (Y)
- Hence (Y)
- (X) results in (Y)
- (X) causes (Y)
- (X) has an effect on (Y)
- (X) affects (Y)
- (X) is one of the causes of (Y)
- (X) is the reason for (Y)

Examples
- Higher air pollution levels in cities are due to the increased use of cars.
- Because of the increased use of cars, pollution levels in cities are rising.
- As a result of the increased use of cars, pollution levels in cities are rising.
- One effect of the increased use of cars is higher pollution levels in cities.
- Cars are used increasingly for urban transport. As a consequence, pollution levels in cities are worsening.
- Increased use of cars for urban transport adversely affects pollution levels in cities.
- Increased use of cars for urban transport is one of the causes of worsening pollution levels in cities.

Exercise

Read the following extracts and recognise the cause-and-effect patterns by doing the following:
1. Identify the cue words that signal cause or effect
2. Identify the sequence of cause and effect (which was presented first?)

Text A:

If all anxious language learners do not possess cognitive deficits, why, then, are they anxious? Recently, I have begun to see an analogy between such things as unflattering clothing and bad hair-cuts and foreign language anxiety. When we wear clothing that is unbecoming or have a “bad hair day,” we feel uncomfortable because not only do we not feel like ourselves, we feel that we are presenting a less positive version of ourselves to the world than we normally do. In an analogous way, few people can appear equally intelligent, sensitive, witty, and so on when speaking a second language as when speaking their first; this disparity between how we see ourselves and how we think others see us has been my consistent explanation for language learners’ anxieties. To deny the reality of foreign language anxiety is illogical as well as insensitive to the experience and needs of many language learners and teachers.

Adapted from:
Horwitz, E. K. (2000). It ain't over 'til it's over: On foreign language anxiety, first language deficits, and the confounding of variables. *The Modern Language Journal, 84*(2), 256-259.

Text B:

Second, analyses of the data revealed that most of the students were willing to participate in interpersonal conversations; however, perhaps due to anxiety, low English proficiency, or other reasons, many of them did not like to risk using/speaking English in class. In addition, more than one third of the participants felt anxious in their English language classrooms. They feared being negatively evaluated and were apprehensive of speech communication and tests. The students' unwillingness to communicate was significantly positively correlated with their FL anxiety. Moreover, their unwillingness to communicate and their FL anxiety were significantly correlated to their self-rated English proficiency and access to English.

Adapted from:
Liu, M., & Jackson, J. (2008). An exploration of Chinese EFL learners' unwillingness to communicate and foreign language anxiety. *The Modern Language Journal, 92*(1), 71-86.

Text C:

In order to promote their students' willingness to use/speak the target language and reduce their anxiety in class, it may be necessary for EFL teachers to encourage the students to practice English and gain more exposure to the language. For EFL learners who have little contact with English in their daily lives (for such reasons as starting to learn the language late, large classes, and little contact with native speakers), practice is essential. They need to practice using/speaking English both in and outside the classroom, with different people, and in a range of situations. This practice can help them become more confident and at ease when using and talking in English with others in various contexts.

Adapted from:
Liu, M., & Jackson, J. (2008). An exploration of Chinese EFL learners' unwillingness to communicate and foreign language anxiety. *The Modern Language Journal, 92*(1), 71-86.

Example essay

Below is a cause-and-effect essay which was written using the block structure. Identify the various structural aspects in this essay, i.e. causes, effects, and structure words, and label them appropriately in the column on the right.

Essay Prompt: *More and more women are working outside the home and some women are now the major salary earners in their families. What are the causes of this, and what effect is this having on families and society?*

In the past, many women worked at home to take care of domestic duties such as looking after young children, cooking and cleaning. Women's liberation and feminism have meant that this situation has been transformed, and in contemporary society women are playing an almost equal role to men in terms of work outside the home. This has had significant consequences, both in terms of the family, for example by improving quality of life and increasing children's sense of independence, and also for society itself with greater gender equality.	

The main reasons behind the increase of women in the workplace are women's liberation and feminism. The women's liberation movement originated in the late 19th century and gained momentum in the 1960s. Feminist ideas were popularized by authors such as Simone de Beauvoir. As a consequence of this, new legislation emerged, granting women equal rights to men in many fields, in particular employment. Because of feminist ideas, women have taken up roles which were previously seen as being for men only, while men have also taken on roles formerly associated with women, most importantly those related to child rearing. As a result of this, women have been empowered to pursue their own careers and interests outside the home.

These changes have led to some significant effects on both family life and society as a whole.

Although on average the earnings of a woman in her lifetime are generally lower than those of a man in the same profession, she can nevertheless make a significant contribution to her family's income. The most important consequence of this increase in income is an improved quality of life. By helping to maintain a steady income for the family, the woman reduces the financial burden on the husband, hence improving both the husband's and the wife's emotional wellbeing. Additionally, the purchasing power of the family will also be raised. This means that the family can afford more luxuries such as a family car and foreign travel.

A further effect on the family is the promotion of independence in the children. Some might argue that having both parents working outside the home might be damaging to the children because of a lack of parental attention. However, children in such families often learn to look after themselves at an earlier age, and their parents often rely on them to help with the housework. These responsibilities teach them important life skills.

As regards society, the most significant impact of women going to work is greater gender equality. In greater numbers, women are becoming politicians, engineers, lawyers, company managers and even CEOs. Having women in these roles has led to greater equality for women in all areas of life, not just employment. For example, women today have much stronger legal rights to protect themselves against violence, exploitation and discrimination.

In conclusion, the increasing number of women at work has brought about some important changes to family life, including improved quality of life and increased independence for children, as well as affecting society itself. The sexes are still a long way from being equal in all areas of life; however, the challenge for the present century is to ensure that full equality becomes the norm in every country and society.

Adapted from
Smith, S. (2020). Cause & effect essays. *EAPFoundation.com*. Retrieved July 21, 2020 from https://www.eapfoundation.com/writing/essays/cande/